then there were a great many such scenes playing themselves out in Fatehpur Sikri at this time as Akbar's plastic, inquiring mind analysed everything of interest around him. When Hakim Ali Geelani, a Unani* physician of renown, arrived at the Mughal court from Persia, Akbar ordered several bottles containing the urine of healthy and sick people as well as that of cattle and asses to be presented to the hakim for the detection of disease. Fortunately for the physician, he was said to have diagnosed each one correctly and thereby became a valued and favourite courtier of Akbar. Badauni was somewhat less enthralled with the young Shia physician and he wrote that 'his excellence in acquired knowledge and especially the science of medicine is extreme…but he is a youth, self-opinionated and of limited experience…. It sometimes happens,' added Badauni with caustic wit, 'that a patient after taking one of his draughts speedily has a taste of the draught of extinction.'

Another experiment conducted around this time was prompted by the arrival at court of a man with no ears, just a flap of skin where the ears would have been. But even without ears, the man could hear everything around him provoking considerable amazement. Akbar wanted to understand if there might be a 'natural language', a zuban-i-qudrut, which would be spoken even if it wasn't heard and learnt through childhood. He then ordered that twenty infants be placed in a specially constructed sarai and attended to by wet nurses and attendants who were told strictly never to talk to their charges. As Fatehpur Sikri resonated with the many languages of the numerous itinerant visitors, in 'Gung Mahal',† as it was popularly known, the infants grew up in hushed and disconcerting silence. A few years later Akbar rode past the Gung Mahal again, and stopped by to visit the children. They communicated only in grunts and gestures and no natural language, concluded the Padshah, had spontaneously evolved in the silence that surrounded them.

In the ibadat khana, Akbar continued to search out truths in their many beguiling forms. These philosophical discussions, initiated by Shaikh Mubarak and his sons, greatly enchanted Akbar, as we have seen, who had not had a formal introduction to these ideas in his boyhood. Now, Akbar admitted, these high voltage exchanges between articulate and learned men enthralled him. 'I have organized this majlis for the purpose only that the facts of every religion, whether Hindu or Muslim, be brought out in the open,' said Akbar, according to an early recension of the *Akbarnama*. 'The